Before You Submit a Digital Forensics Request

A one-page guide for officers and investigators

BEGIN WITH THE QUESTION

The examiner needs to know what the investigation is trying to establish, locate, confirm, or exclude. A requested tool action is not the same thing as an investigative objective.

01 GIVE THE EXAMINER A QUESTION THEY CAN ACT ON

USEFUL OBJECTIVES	REQUESTS THAT NEED CLARIFICATION
• Identify communications between named parties during a defined date range. • Determine whether the device was used to access a named account or service. • Locate images, documents, or location data relevant to a specific incident.	• "Dump the phone." • "Get everything." • "Run Cellebrite on it." • A list of tools without the question the evidence should help answer.

02 BEFORE THE HANDOFF

- [ ] **Authority:** Identify the authority, where the documentation is stored, and any expiration or limits.
- [ ] **Scope:** Name the devices, accounts, data types, date ranges, and people covered by the request.
- [ ] **Targets:** Provide known contacts, usernames, phone numbers, aliases, applications, keywords, and dates.
- [ ] **Context:** Explain facts that may change how the request is approached, including remote-wipe risk or time-sensitive concerns.
- [ ] **Condition:** Record whether the device is on or off, networked or isolated, damaged, wet, or previously accessed.
- [ ] **Credentials:** State whether credentials are known, but transmit them only through the agency-approved method.

03 PROTECT THE EVIDENCE

Follow agency policy for handling, isolation, packaging, and transfer. Do not explore the device, change settings, or place sensitive credentials on the intake form. Document any preservation action or change already made.

A COMPLETE REQUEST DOES NOT REPLACE A CONVERSATION

When authority, scope, device condition, safety, or urgency is unclear, contact the forensic unit before taking additional action.